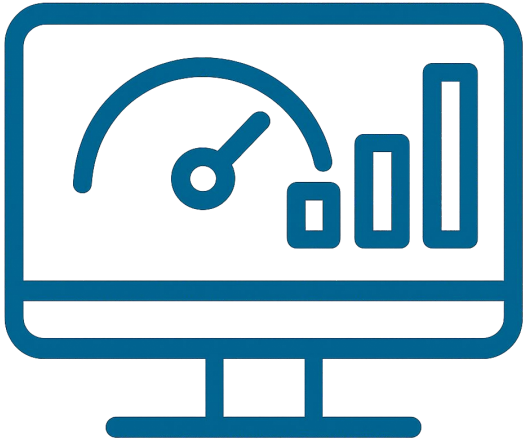
The 8 Agile Metrics Every Team Should Understand

Clear definitions, healthy usage, and what they reveal about your process.



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Why Agile Metrics Matter

Agile metrics help teams see what's really happening beneath the surface. They highlight patterns, reveal bottlenecks, and show whether your process is improving.

- They expose trends you can't see day-to-day
- They help teams focus on outcomes, not opinions
- They support continuous improvement
- They spark healthier conversations

How to Use These Metrics

Agile metrics are most powerful when they're used to guide conversations, not to enforce control. Treat them as signals that help your team learn, adapt, and improve over time.

- Look for trends, not single data points
- Combine metrics to see the full picture
- Use them to ask better questions
- Never compare one team's metrics to another's

Understanding Story Points

A team-specific measure of user-story complexity — not a measure of team productivity.

Used for planning and as the base for several Agile metrics, including velocity.

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Metric 1: Average Velocity

The average story points completed across recent sprints.

Used to plan sprint capacity and forecast delivery.

Metric 2: Velocity Variance

How stable your team’s velocity is across sprints.

Large swings signal unpredictable delivery and unstable planning.

Metric 3: Committed vs. Completed

The percentage of committed story points completed in a sprint.

Reveals how effectively a team manages its sprint commitments.

Metric 4: Scope Change

The percentage of work added or removed after sprint commitment.

Shows how stable the sprint plan stayed through execution.

Metric 5: Backlog Health

The ratio of ready story points to average velocity.

Shows how prepared the team is for upcoming sprints.

Metric 6: Automated Test Coverage

The percentage of code covered by automated tests across the codebase.

Indicates software quality and supports faster, safer deployments.

Metric 7: Post Production Defects

The number of new defects found in production each sprint.

Reflects release quality and highlights gaps in testing or refinement.

Metric 8: Cycle Time

The time a user story spends in progress until it meets the Definition of Done.

Highlights how long work takes and reveals opportunities to improve flow.

Use metrics to spark conversations, not pressure

When teams feel safe to inspect and adapt, everything improves.

Want to go deeper?

Read the full article at ericspink.medium.com